

IDEOLOGY AND LITERATURE

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It is possible to argue that “myth” as Barthes uses it in *Mythologies*, functions as a synonym of ideology. As a term ideology is hard to define. But one of the most pervasive definitions of the term holds that it refers to the body of beliefs and representations that sustain and legitimate current power relationships. Roland Barthes in *Mythologies* analyzes the insidious ways in which the societies create and perpetuate myths. He argues modern myths are created with a reason, that they are formed to perpetuate an idea of society that adheres to the current ideologies of the ruling class and its media. As we inhabit a world of signs which support existing power structures and which purport to be natural. Ideology promotes the values and interests of dominant groups within society. And as Terry Eagleton beautifully explains in his book *I deology* “a dominant power may legitimate itself by promoting beliefs and values congenial to it: naturalizing and universalizing such beliefs so as to render them self-evident and apparently inevitable, denigrating ideas which might challenge it, excluding rival forms of thought and obscuring social reality in ways convenient to itself”. Thus as it can be clearly seen there is a common point in both how Eagleton defines ideology and Barthes’s interpretation of myth as the Notion of a socially constructed reality which is passed of as “natural”. And the opinions and values of that power-holder class is declared as “universal truths”. Barthes argues that the real power relations in society between classes, between coloniser and colonised, between men and women are obscured, wiped out, or their political threat is lessened. The role of language comes to the foreground in this context, not as an instrument of real communication but of intimidation which seeks to establish a specific version of the events (i.e that of the power-holders) as “the sole valid interpretation “and to marginalize those versions which contradict it. The role of literature is vital in this context. By definition novel is a subversive genre which on the surface seemingly catering to the needs of the “petit bourgeoisie “(as Barthes calls it), but in fact showing it a mirror of its ugly face, forcing it to acknowledge its reality. So novel, more than any other form of genre which is more like our lives because of this very reason is the most disturbing of all. And the novel writer, even though he sometimes may deny it (which is the case in most of the post modern novels) has a message in his mind, not necessarily sharing the ideology of the power-holders is a threat.

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Introduction

Ideology is accepted as a commonsense view of things presented by the powerholder class. In this way the interests of the ruling class is secured. While Althusser, a Marxist critic, names this as an “imaginary consciousness”, Roland Barthes, a post-modernist calls it as “myth”. Both of them agree that this is a weapon of the powerholders used to inject the dominant ideology of the society. Another Marxist critic,

Terry Eagleton shares the same idea saying that ideology does not only inject its own beliefs but it also “denigrates ideas which might challenge it”, excluding rival forms of thought, “obscuring social reality”. The use of language by the power holders as a weapon to inject the dominant ideology of the society is argued by Lacan and Kristeva as well. What can be the role of literature in this context? Since literature is created to cater to the needs of the powerful class in any existing society, it will pay lip service to the existing power structure. But the subversive nature of literature, especially novel as a genre would not abide by the rules of that society. Seemingly catering to the needs of that society, it questions, challenges and exposes the weakness of the society which is best exemplified in Cervantes's *Don Quixote*.

Althusser defines ideology as a representation of “the imaginary relationship of individuals to their real conditions of existence.”¹ As a term ideology is hard to define. But one of the most pervasive definitions of the term holds that it refers to the body of beliefs and representations that sustain and legitimate current power relationships. If this line of argument is followed then, “a dominant system of ideology” is accepted as a commonsense view of things by the dominated class and thus the interest of the dominant class is secured. According to Althusser's definition of ideology we can say that it distorts our perceptions of the real and our true social conditions. He further argues that this imaginary consciousness is attained through “ideological state apparatuses”² that perpetuate the dominant ideology in society. These “ideological state apparatuses” include all social institutions such as education, politics, law and religion. The use of language by the power holders as a weapon to inject the dominant ideology of the society is argued by Lacan and Kristeva as well.

It is possible to argue that “myth” as Roland Barthes uses it in *Mythologies*, functions as a synonym of ideology. Barthes in *Mythologies* analyses the insidious ways in which societies create and perpetuate myths. He argues modern myths are created with a reason, that they are formed to perpetuate an idea of society that adheres to the current ideologies of the ruling class and its media. As we inhabit a world of signs which support existing power structures and which purport to be natural.

So ideology promotes the values and interests of dominant groups within society which is perfectly expressed by Terry Eagleton in his book *Ideology* :

“A dominant power may legitimate itself by promoting beliefs and values congenial to it; naturalizing and universalizing such beliefs as to render them self-evident and apparently inevitable ; denigrating ideas which might challenge it; excluding rival forms of thought, perhaps by some unspoken but systematic logic; and obscuring social reality in ways convenient to itself. Such ‘mystification’, as is commonly known, frequently takes the form of masking or suppressing social conflicts, from which arises the conception of ideology as an imaginary resolution of real contradictions.”³

Thus it can be clearly seen there is a common point in how Althusser, Barthes and Eagleton define ideology. Barthes's interpretation of myth as the notion of a socially constructed reality which is passed off as “natural” is shared by Eagleton as well. And the values and opinions of that power-holder class is declared as “universal truths” in this naturalization process.

Barthes argues in this way the real power relations in society between coloniser and colonised, between men and women are obscured, wiped out, glossed over or their political threat is lessened. What Barthes wants to achieve is “to challenge the “innocence” and “naturalness” of cultural texts and practises which were capable of producing all sorts of supplementary meanings or connotations to use Barthes's favourite term.”⁴ Although objects, gestures and practises have a certain utilitarian function, they are not resistant to the imposition of meaning. So every single object or gesture is susceptible to the imposition of meaning, nothing is resistant to this process. So in his work *Mythologies* Barthes begins by making explicit the meanings of apparently neutral objects and then moves on to consider the social and

¹ Cutajar, Maureen. “Louis Althusser: Ideology and Literature “. Suite101.com.2010,15.09.2011
< <http://maureenecutajar.suite101.com> >

² Althusser, Louis. *On Ideology*. London: Verso, 2008 :16.

³ Eagleton qtd in. McNeill, Tony. “Roland Barthes: Mythologies (1957)”.

Sunderland University: 1999,24.09.2010:4<<http://seacoast.sunderland.ac.uk/~os/Otmc/myth.htm>. >

⁴ Ibid:2

historical conditions they obscure. So *Mythologies* is a “study of the ways in which mass culture – controlled by la petit bourgeoisie constructs this mythological reality and encourages conformity to its own values”⁵. Then the role of the mythologist, as Barthes sees it, is to expose these signs as the artificial constructs they are, to reveal their workings and show that what appears to be natural is, in fact, determined by history. For example the tone of much French journalism’s reporting of the conflict in Algeria at that time –is marked by an attempt to drown out or disguise the true violence of war. “Language here is not instrument of communication but of intimidation”⁶ which seeks out to pass off a specific version of events (that of the French state) as the sole valid interpretation and to marginalize those versions which contradict it. So in Barthes’s view myth reinforces the ideology of capitalist society. The essence of myth is that it disguises what are in fact bourgeois representations as facts of a universal nature.

Another point Althusser defends is that : “ Ideology interpellates concrete individuals as concrete subjects “⁷: In that sense the author and the reader of these lines both live “ spontaneously “ or “ naturally” in ideology in the sense that “ man is an ideological animal by nature “ ⁸as Althusser argued. As St. Paul admirably put it, “it is in the “ logos” meaning ideology that we live, move and have our being. What seems to take place outside ideology (in the streets) in reality takes place in ideology.”⁹Thus ideology hails or interpellates individuals as subjects. Thanks to religion or ethics, or other Ideological state Apparatuses in Althusser’ s terminology, “ the subjects work by themselves”¹⁰.And furthermore according to Althusser ideology is bound with class struggle with the counterposing of the ruling class and the exploited class which is in line with Marxist argument as well.

So far we dwell on the similarities between Marxists and Post-Modernists. The difference between them is noticed by Foucault as such: “ Encouraged by Marx and Engels, the working class came to value the regime of the factory as its training school as a disciplined political force, while taking less interest in the fate of the lumpen marginals and the problems of penal justice.”¹¹ In the France of early 70’ies, “Foucault evidently saw as consequences of this historical legacy the marked lack of sympathy of the old communist left for some of the causes and struggles in which he is actively involved then.”¹²

On the other hand Foucault argues that the workings of power is not so simple. He says “if power were never anything but repressive, if it never did anything but to say no,[no one] would be brought to obey it. What makes power hold good, what makes it accepted is simply the fact that it does not only weigh on us as a force that says no ;it also traverses and produces things, it induces pleasure, forms knowledge, produces discourse (ideology /myth) It needs to be considered as a productive network that runs through the whole social body much more than as a negative instance whose function is repression.”

¹³ In Discipline and Punish what [he] wanted to show was how from the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries onward there was a “veritable technological take-off in the productivity of power. Not only did the monarchies of the classical period develop great state apparatuses (the army, the police and fiscal administration but, above all, in this period what one might call a new ‘economy ’ of power was established, that is to say procedures that allowed the effects of power to circulate in a manner at once continuous, uninterrupted, adapted and individualized throughout the entire social body.”¹⁴ He further adds : “ how light power would be, and easy to dismantle no doubt, if all it did was to observe, spy,

⁵ ibid: 3

⁶ ibid: 3-4

⁷. Althusser, Louis. *On Ideology*. London:Verso,2008 :39

⁸ ibid:45

⁹ ibid:45

¹⁰ ibid:55

¹¹ Foucault,Michel.*Power:Essential Works of Foucault 1954-1984 Volume 3*. editor James D. Faubion. London: Penguin Books, 2002:xv

¹² ibid:xv

¹³ Foucault, Michel. *Power:Essential Works of Foucault 1954-1984 Volume 3*. editor James D. Faubion. London: Penguin Books, 2002:120

¹⁴ ibid:120

detect, prohibit and punish; but it incites, provokes, produces. It is not simply eye and ear: it makes people act and speak “¹⁵ The kind of power Foucault talks about makes individuals “ “subjects”: that is subject to someone else by control and dependence and tied to his own identity by a conscience or self-knowledge. Both meanings suggest a form of power that subjugates and makes subject to”¹⁶. So Foucault’s main point was about presence in modern history the techniques of power which do not bear any distinctive form of regime –socialist, communist, fascist or liberal –that uses them. The technical inventions available to the democratic West are common to all these other regimes. What Foucault means, therefore that “the apparent neutrality and political invisibility of techniques of power is what makes them so dangerous”¹⁷, which is a common point with what Barthes argues. So he underlines the fact that the state’s power is both an individualizing and a totalizing form of power.(and that is one of the reasons for its strength) He argues “ never, I think in the history of human societies –even in the old -Chinese society –has there been such a tricky combination in the same political structures of individualization techniques and of totalization procedures”¹⁸. In one of his last interviews he said: “nothing is more untenable than a political regime which is indifferent to truth, but nothing is more dangerous than a political system that claims to prescribe the truth”¹⁹

He is interested in the possibility of gaining, helped by historical analysis, new and more effective ways of seeing. These new ways of seeing are concerned especially with the relations of power and knowledge.

So what is the role of literature in this context ?As it is perceived by Foucault as well, at the turn of the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries relations of discourse, power, everyday life, and truth were knotted together in a new way one in which literature is entangled.

Before the seventeenth century “ the more extraordinary the tale, the more capable it was of casting spell or of persuading “²⁰ or as in Mircea Eliade ‘s terms it is “sacred”²¹. But with the seventeenth century it is no longer sacred, it is no longer interested in “ideals and perfect forms “²². For such a man, the universe is not a unity but an infinite number of pieces like himself. There is little connection between his life and cosmos. This man is the man in the novel, the familiar protagonist and in eighteenth century he is more alone in himself than any other previous figure in English Literature. This change from sacred to profane or as Foucault calls it from “exemplary fabulous” into a “fable “²³ of obscure life marks the change in literature. “This is a society secularized, desacramentalized, in which there is a radical secularization of death, marriage and birth. From that aspect *Don Quixote* is not only a farewell to knight-errantry and its medieval suppositions but also a farewell to the sacred in man”²⁴. The Don, indeed, sees real things –the basin of the barber, but chooses to ignore them in favour of his conception of them– and he alleges that “the basin” in fact is Mambrino’s helmet. So the Don creates the world in his own image.” His true vocation is to create a way of seeing, just as every novelist must transform reality into

¹⁵ During, Simon. *Foucault and Literature: Towards a Genealogy of Writing*. London and New York : Routledge, 1992:134

¹⁶ Foucault, Michel. *Power: Essential Works of Foucault 1954-1984 Volume 3*. editor James D. Faubion. London: Penguin Books, 2002:xiv-xv

¹⁷ *ibid*:xiv

¹⁸ *ibid*:334

¹⁹ Foucault, Michel. *Power: Essential Works of Foucault 1954-1984 Volume 3*. editor James D. Faubion. London: Penguin Books, 2002:332

²⁰ *ibid*:120

²¹ qtd.in Karl, Frederick R. *A Reader's Guide to The Development of The English Novel in The Eighteenth Century*. London: Thames and Hudson, 1974.

²² *ibid*:174

²³ Foucault, Michel. *Power: Essential Works of Foucault 1954-1984 Volume 3*. editor James D. Faubion. London: Penguin Books, 2002:175

²⁴ Karl, Frederick., R. *A Reader's Guide to The Development of The English Novel in The Eighteenth Century*. London: Thames and Hudson, 1974:26

something both more and less than the original object”²⁵. For Foucault writers like Cervantes escapes “the full force of the episteme and exemplifies the pressures at work best: for example Don Quixote: the novel’s hero reads the world not in terms of representations but in terms of analogies. It is a sign of classicism’s emergence that the Don is regarded as mad “²⁶ or else there is a reason in his madness. The Don explains to Sancho that “the enchanters and sages change and alter our perceptions and transform them according to their pleasure and their desire is either to favour us or to injure us”.²⁷ Furthermore the Don argues that “their wisdom (enchanters and sages) is such that they “ change and alter all our deeds, and transform that according to their pleasure and their desire either to favour us or injure us. So what seems to you to be a barber’s basin appears to me to be Mambrino’s helmet, and to another as something else.”²⁸

Obviously Don Quixote is seen as mad, because he is not in harmony with the existing ideology of his time. Simon During says “ beneath Cervantes’s mockery and burlesque is an archetypal or mythical response that we all have to the lunatic –our awareness of him as the artist.”²⁹ What the Don suggests then, is the dualism of the novel: imagination and chivalric knight-errantry reflect a radical distaste for an existing society.

So we have the paradox of Cervantes’s point of view and the experience of novelists after him: that “ no matter how imaginative, poetic, ideologically pure the novelist was in his intentions, the novel form would itself force him into social attitudes, into confrontation with routine activities, even to the extent of making him assume an adversary position without his consciously knowing it.”³⁰

The new form of the novel would be psychologically realistic, it must relate to the undercurrents of feeling that individuals experience, ;and such feelings, in the late seventeenth and early eighteenth centuries were secular, anarchic, iconoclastic-and could be best expressed in the activities of rapists, pirates, sensualists and criminals of every type. “Because both authors and audience sensed anarchy and criminality in themselves”³¹ Defoe clearly saw the connection between the anarchic criminal and the respectable, secular individualist. Frederick Karl aptly suggests that “one thinks of Georg Lukacs’s distinction between epic and novel in which the latter forces uncertainties and unknowns : “ The novel is the epic of an age in which the extensive totality of life is no longer directly given, in which the immanence of meaning in life has become a problem, yet which still thinks in terms of totality.”³²

Although the novelists paid lip service to common sense, the novel itself rejected objective consciousness as a way of experiencing reality and instead encouraged a kind of subjective reality dependent on the individual, not on society. “Objective reality is indeed treated as a “myth”, while objective reality was handled as real, the thing-in-itself.”³³

In this context the important role of literature is analysed by Frederick Karl aptly as such:

“... [literature] exposes the terrible weaknesses of every community and demonstrates how societies through myths try to disguise their serious flaws”³⁴. Foucault agrees with this view and says “though literature belongs to the great system of constraint” all the same, it has a special place in that system

²⁵ qtd.in Karl, Frederick., *R.A Reader's Guide to The Development of The English Novel in The Eighteenth Century*. London: Thames and Hudson, 1974:29

²⁶ *ibid*:19

²⁷ *ibid*:56

²⁸ qtd in *ibid*:204

²⁹ During, Simon. *Foucault and Literature:Towards a Genealogy of Writing*. London and New York: Routledge, 1992,

³⁰ qtd.in Karl, Frederick., *R.A Reader's Guide to The Development of The English Novel in The Eighteenth Century*. London: Thames and Hudson, 1974:61

³¹ Karl, Frederick., *R.A Reader's Guide to The Development of The English Novel in The Eighteenth Century*. London: Thames and Hudson, 1974:49

³² *ibid*:51

³³ *ibid*:53

³⁴ Foucault, Michel. *Power:Essential Works of Foucault 1954-1984 Volume 3*. editor James D. Faubion. London: Penguin Books, 2002:174

“determined to seek quotidian beneath the quotidian itself, to cross boundaries, to ruthlessly or insidiously bring out secrets in the open, to displace rules or codes, to compel the unmentionable to be told, it will thus tend to place itself outside the law, or at least take on the burden of scandal, transgression, or revolt. More than any other form of language it remains the discourse of “infamy “ :it has the duty of saying what is most resistant to being said-the worst, the secret, the most insufferable, the shameless”³⁵ It is this special quality of literature which makes it a unique way of telling the truth.

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³⁵ *ibid*:174